



Putting a Leash on Spam



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VSNL recently announced that it would not allow any mail that does not originate from a VSNL e-mail identity to be sent via their SMTP servers in India.

This will mean that subscribers to the VSNL Internet service who are not using the e-mail account they were provided with when they signed up will need to start looking for another way to send e-mail. If you use an e-mail service other than that of VSNL, you had better hope it provides you with a server for outgoing mail. Users of Web-based e-mail services really won't be affected.

But for VSNL subscribers this is a good thing!

The primary reason that VSNL, or any other ISP for that matter, has had to do this is spam. ISPs all over the world have been making serious efforts to reduce spam originating from their servers for quite a while now and VSNL has finally decided to follow suit.

Advances in technology have made the electronic transmission of information increasingly easy. This has encouraged the indiscriminate use of e-mail by marketers to push information about their products to unsuspecting consumers.

The sending of unsolicited e-mail via open relay servers like the one that VSNL has maintained since it began providing Internet services in India, has become a nuisance in more ways than one. On the one hand, you are forced to deal with meaningless advertising messages filling your mailbox and keeping you from the ones that are really important. On the other hand, spam also clogs the networks and consumes bandwidth, which is pretty scarce for Internet users in India anyway.

While it is significant that VSNL, the single largest ISP in India, has finally decided to take some serious steps to control spam, this can only work if all other ISPs in the country take similar action. This has to be backed up with legislation that will penalise the bulk mailing by organisations or individuals using ISP resources.

Perhaps this kind of legislation will follow in the near future, and hopefully it won't be just another paper tiger.

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